

O'Hara Quells UTEP Storm

By JAN PETRANEK
Citizen Sportswriter

EL PASO — Arizona pitcher Mickey O'Hara, the hard-talking, hard-throwing Irishman, harked back to his moment of glory at Susanville State Prison . . .

. . . Where he was nothing more than a visitor.

"That's the first time I've pitched nine full innings in two years. Imagine that, two years," Mickey said. "The last time I went nine was at Susanville. I was stationed at the Sierra Army Depot in northern California, and our team beat the inmates. Heck, they were a good team. The score was something like 3-1.

"I was a member of the 980th Military Police Co., so a few of the inmates bugged me.

'Hey, this guy is a cop and you know about cops,' they would say. Really, I'm glad they opened the gates and let us out. I didn't want to stay there," Mickey said. "You know, the service can be enjoyable — when you get out."

O'Hara, the military policeman, turned fireman Saturday as Arizona split a Western Athletic Conference double-header with Texas - El Paso at wind-swept Dudley Field. O'Hara answered an alarm in the opener and methodically put out UTEP, 6-5. The Miners recovered to single UA in the second game, 8-7.

The defeat was painful. It pushed UA into a firstplace tie with Arizona State in the WAC Southern Division, wasting away the one-game lead the

Cats had assumed after Friday's 5-3 win over UTEP. Both Arizona schools stand at 2-1.

O'Hara, the happy-go-lucky, I - do-not-have-a-care-in - the world type, has an individualistic idea of what pitching is all about.

"Sometimes, maybe I relax too much. That can be a problem. You have to maintain a certain pitch or temper out there," he said. "Still, I hate when players are tense around me. So we laugh and tell jokes during the game, and everybody is loose. Even in pressure situations, I'll trade lines with the guys in the infield."

UTEP coach Andy Cohen, when asked why he didn't pinch-hit for pitcher Larry Smith with two outs and the

bases loaded, barked at his assistant coach, Krush Kruschwitz.

"Darn it, Krush, let me know when it's the last inning, like I asked you to do. Heck, I wouldn't have let that kid bat if I'd known it was the ninth inning."

Krush was perplexed. "Gee, Andy, you never asked me to tell you what inning it is."

"Didn't I? Darn, that cost us a game," Cohen said.

In defense of Cohen, the old, rusting scoreboard at Dudley Field remains dormant during the UTEP games, so there isn't a ready reference as to what inning it is.

For O'Hara, Saturday was an important day.

"I didn't come to Arizona to be a relief pitcher. Every

pitcher wants to be a starter, and I'm no exception. I don't want to wait until our Alaska trip in June for a starting turn," he said.

Anyway, I don't like being a relief pitcher. You become a sadist. The only way you get into the game is if your own teammates get bombed. You don't hope for that, but you do sit in the bullpen and say, 'He's starting to get tired and they're hitting him now.' If you're a starter, you don't have to think like that. It's your game."

Tomorrow, Arizona will meet Northern Arizona University in a 3 p.m. game at UA Field. The Cats take on New Mexico here in a WAC series this weekend.

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